

■■ Desire Paths

■ What is it?

People like shortcuts when doing things.

Users naturally find the easiest, most intuitive way to complete a task—even if it's not the “official” route.

For example, people often cut across a lawn instead of following the long paved path. In design, users might skip a button and use a faster method they've discovered.

■■ History

The concept of **desire paths** comes from urban planning and landscape design. Planners noticed that when people repeatedly walked the same shortcut across grass, it created a worn path.

Over time, many campuses and parks began paving these “desire paths” because they revealed the routes people truly preferred. In UX, the same principle applies—users create their own shortcuts.

■ The Psychology Behind It

Humans value **speed, ease, and convenience**.

- If a process feels long or complicated, people will look for shortcuts.
- Repeated shortcuts show real user intent.
- Ignoring them risks designing features that people won't use.

By studying these patterns, designers can make products more natural and efficient.

■■ Why It Matters

Desire paths can reveal:

- Usability gaps
- Real user behavior

- Broken design logic
- Accidental misuse of features
- Inefficient UX journeys
- Missed opportunities if ignored

■ How to Apply It

- **Analyze behavior** → use heatmaps, recordings, or analytics.
- **Adapt layouts** → design around natural user flows.
- **Reduce steps** → cut unnecessary clicks or actions.
- **Streamline common paths** → prioritize the shortcuts people already use.
- **Design for intent** → focus on what users do, not what you expect them to do.

■ Theory in Action

- **Notion** supports power users with keyboard shortcuts, making workflows faster.
- **Campuses and parks** often pave new sidewalks where people naturally create their own walking routes.

■ Final Thought

People always look for the fastest, easiest way to do things. These shortcuts aren't problems—they're insights.

By watching what users actually do, designers can adapt and create experiences that feel effortless and natural.